Built to battle

By Caleb James

For The Journal

POWDERSVILLE — The West-Oak wrestling team punched its ticket to the State Championship after dominating Union County in the third round of the playoffs before outlasting Belton-Honea Path in the Upper State finals to keep its championship hope alive.

The Warriors opened their day with a decisive 57-24 victory over Union County before defeating Belton-Honea Path 44-35 in the Upper State finals to advance to their fifth State Championship match in as many years

The Warriors' opening dual featured an early stumble at 106 pounds, but the momentum quickly shifted in West-Oak's favor. Gunner Mease sparked the turnaround with a technical fall at 120, followed by a first-period pin from AJ DeLaCruz at 126. Peyton Durham added another pin at 132, and Efrian Rivera kept the pressure on the Yellow Jackets with a 16-0 technical fall at 138.

Pins from King Orvosh at 144, Drake Smith at 157 and Sy Strobel at 165 continued the dominant run, as West-Oak built a 33-6 lead. Strobel's pin came just 33 seconds into his match, displaying the Warriors' aggressive approach throughout the dual.

After the win, the Warriors' head coach Derek Strobel summed up the team's mindset going into the Upper State finals match in one word.

"Battle," he said.

And they did exactly that.

Facing Belton-Honea Path in the Upper State finals, West-Oak weathered an early deficit before unleashing a dominant stretch that ultimately decided the match. After dropping the opening match at 113, the Warriors responded with eight straight wins, including six pins and a technical fall.

Mease ignited the run with a pin at 120, followed by first-period pins from Durham at 126, DeLaCruz at 132 and Orvosh at 144. Rivera added a 17-1 technical fall at 138. West-Oak stayed relentless through the middle weights, with K'von Engram's pin at 150, Drake Smith's 11-9 decision at 157 and Strobel's dominant pin at 165 in just 23 seconds fueling a stretch of 44 unanswered points.

Though Belton-Honea Path mounted a late rally in the upper weights, West-Oak's 44-point surge proved too much to overcome.

Coach Strobel said the moment reflected the work his team has put in throughout the season.

“I’m just proud of our kids,” Strobel said. “They do a lot of work, they go out and perform and when you put the time in, results happen.”

With the Upper State title secured, West-Oak now turns its attention to Wednesday’s State Championship.

“Stay healthy, rest, fix little things, learn from what we did today,” Strobel said. “Just try to improve a little bit.”

For Mease, the opportunity to wrestle for the program’s fifth straight State Championship alongside longtime teammates adds extra meaning.

“It means a lot,” he said. “A lot of the guys I grew up wrestling with are seniors, so to get another shot at a State Championship with them means everything.”

West-Oak will wrestle Hanahan on Wednesday at Lexington High School, looking to secure the Warrior’s fifth state title in a row.

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West-Oak 57, Union County 24

*106 — Smith (UC) pinned Swelling, 0:16

113 — Davis (W) won by forfeit

120 — Mease (W) tech. fall Fincher, 15-0

126 — DeLaCruz (W) pinned Cershaw, 1:14

132 — Durham (W) tech. fall Millwood, 16-0

138 — Rivera (W) tech. fall, Murphy, 16-1

144 — Orvosh (W) pinned Tucker, 3:08

150 — Remlcik (UC) pinned Engram, 1:54

157 — Smith (W) pinned Smith, 2:21

165 — Strobel (W) pinned Hill, 0:33

175 — Saxon (W) won by forfiet

190 — Nickade (UC) pinned Ramiro, 0:43

215 — Rodriguez (W) pinned King, 1:11

285 — Castle (UC) pinned Whitfield, 0:45

* — Starting point of match

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West-Oak 44, Belton Honea-Path 35

106 — Wellborn (BHP) pinned Swilling, 0:46

*113 — Brown (BHP) pinned Davis, 1:45

120 — Meace (W) pinned Vang, 3:05

126 — Durham (W) pinned Brown, 1:34

132 — DeLacruz (W) pinned Conway, 0:31

138 — Rivera (W) tech. fall Moore, 17-1

144 — Orvosh (W) pinned Morris, 0:50

150 — Engram (W) pinned Armors, 2:58

157 — Smith (W) dec. Crocker, 11-9

165 — Strobel (W) pinned Dubois, 0:23

175 — Morris (BHP) beat Saxon by disqualification

190 — Laburta (BHP) pinned Ramiro, 1:11

215 — Riddle (BHP) pinned Weston, 1:53

285 — Musia (BHP) pinned Whitfield, 0:57

* — Starting point of match